

# Quality Management System Manual

Example LLC

ISO 9001:2015 · Stage 1 Foundation

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## 1. Quality Policy

At Example LLC, we calibrate measuring and test equipment for manufacturers whose operations depend on reliable and traceable measurement results. Our policy is to perform every calibration using reference standards that are directly traceable to NIST, and no item receives our certificate without a full, documented record of exactly what was measured, in which conditions, with which standards. We apply this rigor whether the equipment comes to our lab by shipment or is handled during an on-site visit. Our customers, particularly in the automotive and aerospace sectors, expect documentation that stands up to the most stringent audit, including traceability and the ability to verify every measurement result against the certificate we issue.

We do not accept shortcuts, especially regarding reporting or documentation. If the supporting measurement records or the condition of equipment do not fully allow us to issue a certificate in line with these expectations, we return the item with a clear explanation and work with the customer to resolve the issue. This stance extends to on-time performance: since our customers' production lines rely on prompt return of calibrated equipment, we actively communicate expected turnaround at job entry, monitor progress at each stage, and identify and correct root causes for any delays.

Quality at Example LLC is not just about compliance but about making sure each certificate we issue can be pulled at any time—by a customer, their customer, or a third-party auditor—and clearly demonstrate what was done, when, using which traceable references. We emphasize the training and oversight of our technical staff to ensure consistent process execution, and we formalize knowledge in written procedures rather than rely solely on tribal knowledge. Issues found after release, whether data errors or process lapses, are always investigated for root cause, and corrective actions are tracked until effective. We recognize that our reputation depends entirely on the integrity of our results and the trust of our customers in the documentation we provide.

## 2. Quality Objectives

We have established and review quality objectives that reflect our operational context and the expectations of our customers. Data from recent years, especially feedback from key customers and our own internal error tracking, inform these priorities. The following objectives are monitored quarterly by management and discussed in detail during management reviews:

- **Certificate Correction Rate:** To uphold our commitment to “audit-proof” calibration documentation, we targeted a reduction in certificate corrections (for errors such as wrong values, units, or missing data) from 6 in 2025 down to 2 or fewer per year, to be consistently achieved by the end of 2026. Progress is tracked by recording error sources, types, and root causes, and corrective actions are analyzed for effectiveness.
- **On-Time Delivery Rate:** Our customers' production continuity often hinges on timely return of their measurement tools. In 2025, our on-time delivery was approximately 88%. By maintaining clear scheduling, active backlog monitoring, and early escalation of bottlenecks, we aim to achieve at least 95% on-time delivery by the end of 2026.
- **In-house Reference Standards Past Due for Recalibration:** Maintaining NIST traceability requires all standards to be recalibrated before expiry. We aim for zero overdue reference standards at any time, with immediate effect ongoing from Q1 2026. Each overdue standard is regarded as a critical nonconformance, triggering both internal review and customer notification when applicable.

These objectives are communicated to all staff, and progress against them is reviewed in monthly team meetings as well as during annual management reviews.

### 3. Scope of the Quality Management System

The Quality Management System (QMS) at Example LLC covers all activities related to the calibration of manufacturers' measuring and test equipment, including dimensional, pressure, temperature, and electrical instruments such as gauges, torque tools, pressure and temperature devices, and multimeters. The system applies to both in-lab calibrations at our facility in Greenville, South Carolina, and mobile/on-site calibrations conducted at customer locations.

Processes covered include customer communications and order entry, scheduling, calibration execution, documentation, issuance of calibration certificates, management of NIST-traceable standards, handling of customer complaints and corrections, and coordination with external calibration providers for our own reference standards. Exclusions are limited to activities or services not offered (e.g., repair or manufacturing of customer equipment, or non-metrological activities). All requirements of ISO 9001:2015 that are applicable to the above activities are included in the QMS.

## 4. Process Overview

The QMS is structured around key process categories: leadership, core, and support processes, each with clear operational responsibilities and defined interdependencies.

### 4.1 Leadership Processes

Leadership at Example LLC is exercised primarily through periodic management reviews, ongoing monitoring of quality objectives, and oversight of competency and process integrity. Dana Whitfield, as owner, is directly involved in major operational decisions, policy setting, and review of nonconforming outputs and systemic issues. The annual management review is planned at the start of each year, with ad-hoc meetings called in case of critical process deviations or customer escalations.

Leadership processes also include the periodic review and approval of documented procedures and the assessment of external context, such as new customer requirements, changes in regulatory guidelines (e.g., NIST or OSHA), and supplier reliability regarding external calibration. Adjustments to resources, such as hiring or equipment upgrades, are reviewed by Dana in consultation with Marcus Bell, factoring in demand forecasts and risk assessments based on recent nonconformances or near-misses. Key leadership processes are triggered either by planned review cycles or in response to significant quality or turnaround deviations flagged by staff.

## 4.2 Core Processes

Calibration Service Provision forms the heart of the business. Customer request intake is the trigger, handled by Theresa Nguyen, who logs job details and confirms scope and turnaround commitments. Shipping receipt triggers internal intake: equipment is unpacked and checked for transit damage or labeling discrepancies. For on-site jobs, Theresa schedules technician deployment; for in-lab jobs, gear is staged for assignment.

Marcus Bell reviews each job's technical scope and assigns it to an appropriate technician based on required discipline (dimensional, pressure, temperature, or electrical). Technicians retrieve relevant NIST-traceable references from inventory, confirm the calibration status and fit-for-use, and document each measurement performed, both electronically using the lab management software and on physical bench notes as required for redundancy. Equipment is clearly marked with a calibration label indicating date, reference used, and next due date. Certificates are drafted and associated documentation attached in the management system.

Before finalization, either Marcus Bell or Dana Whitfield reviews—or spot-checks—the certificate for completeness and correctness of reported data. Any anomalies found (e.g., instrument drift or out-of-tolerance findings) are discussed with the technician or escalated to the customer as needed. Once the certificate is approved, Theresa organizes shipment back to the customer, ensuring label and documentation accuracy, or on-site, the technician delivers the equipment and certificate directly.

Return or post-delivery issues (customer complaints, discovered data errors) are systematically logged by Theresa; the original measurement records are retrieved, and Marcus and the responsible technician conduct a root-cause review before issue resolution or corrected certificate issuance.

### 4.3 Support Processes

Maintenance of Reference Standards ensures calibration activities are based only on traceable, valid standards. Kevin Park operates a rolling tracking system that lists recalibration due dates for all key standards. Sixty days prior to expiration, Kevin triggers shipment to the pre-qualified external calibration supplier. Upon return, the new certificate is logged, assets tagged or relabeled if necessary, and the data updated in both local logs and the lab's management software. Should an incoming standard not meet tolerance, Marcus Bell and Dana Whitfield jointly determine whether prior calibrations must be reviewed or customers notified, documenting all decisions and actions.

Shipping and logistics for all customer equipment and standards are managed by Theresa, using our designated carrier account. She ensures each outgoing package is checked for completeness (equipment, certificate, labels), and all shipments are tracked until confirmed as delivered.

Staff Competency and Training are maintained through Marcus Bell's regular hands-on oversight and annual reviews. New technicians receive structured onboarding and are supervised until Marcus approves their independent work. Any process errors, especially those recurring or linked to particular staff, trigger a targeted training refresh and, if necessary, updates to written procedures.

Lab Management Software is maintained for calibration job tracking, certificate generation, and historical record retention. Backups are scheduled weekly, with daily incremental saves, and the system is periodically tested for recoverability.

Supplier Qualification and Monitoring is overseen by Dana Whitfield, who maintains current documentation from external calibration providers and periodically reviews their performance for turnaround, traceability, and incident response.



## 5. Roles and Responsibilities

Overall management of Example LLC is held by Dana Whitfield, Owner, who sets the quality policy, leads management reviews, and makes final decisions on escalated issues, resource allocation, and supplier relationships. Dana is involved in the review of major nonconformities and ensures that adequate resources—including staffing, equipment, and external provider support—are available to fulfill contractual and legal obligations.

Marcus Bell, Lab Manager, is responsible for day-to-day operational quality in all calibration activities. Marcus assigns technicians to jobs, oversees adherence to documented calibration procedures, conducts certificate reviews, and leads investigations into root causes when process deviations or complaints occur. Marcus supervises the technician team, including new trainees, and directly communicates with Dana on incidents that could indicate systemic risks or require management intervention.

Theresa Nguyen operates the front office, handling all initial customer contact, job logging, scope clarification, shipment intake and dispatch, and invoicing. Theresa is the first point of contact for new or returning jobs, manages communications on timelines and certificates, and ensures all shipment documentation matches customer and internal requirements. She escalates complaints and certificate issues to Marcus or Dana and tracks follow-up actions to closure.

Kevin Park maintains the inventory and recalibration schedule for all NIST-traceable reference standards. He organizes the logistics with the external calibration provider, receives and logs new certificates, and checks for specification compliance. Kevin immediately escalates any out-of-tolerance findings to Marcus and Dana and participates in follow-up reviews as needed.

Technicians are assigned jobs according to their competencies (dimensional, pressure, temperature, or electrical domains) as determined by Marcus Bell. Technicians are responsible for following documented calibration or measurement procedures, ensuring proper use of standards, recording data promptly and accurately, and maintaining their workstations. They participate in investigations of nonconformances linked to their jobs and in staff training sessions as needed.

A single trainee technician currently operates under direct supervision of Marcus Bell. The trainee completes all work-step checklists and submits results for review prior to certificate issuance.

## 6. Document Control Procedure

All quality system documents—including policies, procedures, work instructions, forms, and technical records—are controlled electronically within the lab management software and, for key procedures, as hard copies in a controlled binder. Document changes are initiated either in planned reviews or in response to process changes or nonconformances. The initiator drafts or edits the document, annotating the revision date and proposed changes. Marcus Bell reviews all drafts for technical accuracy, then forwards finalized versions to Dana Whitfield for approval and release.

Outdated or superseded documents are archived in a read-only folder. Theresa Nguyen ensures only the current versions of relevant instructions are available at technician benches and in calibration work areas. Controlled forms bear version numbers; upon revision, older versions are physically removed from circulation and replaced.

External documents (NIST standards, customer-specific requirements) are tracked and updated by Kevin Park or Theresa Nguyen, with review by Marcus or Dana as needed. Access to quality documents is available to all staff; edits or deletions are restricted to authorized personnel. Any unintended changes or suspected loss of control is escalated immediately to Marcus Bell.

## 7. Internal Audit Procedure

An internal audit program is maintained to provide independent checks that the QMS meets ISO 9001, customer, and regulatory requirements, and that procedures are consistently followed. Dana Whitfield ensures that the audit plan is maintained and that audits take place at least annually, supplemented by process-specific spot audits as needed.

Each audit cycle begins with a defined scope and checklist based on recent risks, customer complaints, and prior nonconformities. Dana appoints an auditor not directly responsible for the area being audited, typically cross-training Theresa or Kevin to perform these audits to maintain objectivity.

Auditors review process records, observe activity on-site, and interview staff. Deviations are documented with referenced objective evidence. At audit close, findings are discussed with the area lead (typically Marcus Bell), and corrective actions are assigned with follow-up deadlines. Audit reports are presented at the next management review and tracked for closure by Dana Whitfield.

Missed audits (due to resource or scheduling constraints) are logged as nonconformities and prioritized for rescheduling. Repeat findings trigger an escalation and review of training or procedural adequacy.

## 8. Management Review Procedure

Management review occurs annually or after major process changes, nonconformities, or at the request of Dana Whitfield. The review is scheduled by Dana and includes Marcus and relevant staff (Theresa and Kevin for their domains, select technicians if agenda requires). The agenda covers:

- Progress and data on quality objectives
- Audit results and findings from the previous period
- Customer feedback and complaints
- Status of corrective and preventive actions
- Resource and equipment needs
- Risks and opportunities (especially relating to traceability, turnaround, and supplier performance)
- Changes in regulatory or customer requirements
- Recommendations for changes to the QMS

Meeting outputs include updated action items, resource or competency adjustments, and assigned owners for tracked improvement projects. All action items and review notes are documented by Theresa Nguyen and circulated to attendees. Significant decisions (policy changes, supplier changes, new equipment purchases) are communicated to all staff at weekly team meetings.

Interim or special reviews are called as soon as major nonconformities are detected, or if significant customer escalation occurs. Decisions from such reviews are documented in the same manner and linked to regular review logs.

## 9. Continuous Improvement Procedure

Continuous improvement is embedded in day-to-day operations. Every complaint, audit finding, or process error is reviewed for root cause. Marcus Bell leads corrective action investigations, using input from the responsible technician and other stakeholders. Issues are logged by Theresa Nguyen, tracked in the management software, and flagged for follow-up at weekly meetings.

Corrective actions are assigned to relevant staff, with deadlines and effectiveness criteria set by Marcus or Dana. For problems relating to documentation or training gaps, Markus reviews and revises procedures or initiates additional training sessions. Dana Whitfield monitors overall trends in nonconformities, customer feedback, and objective metrics; where patterns emerge, major improvement projects are launched (such as overhaul of a process, system upgrade, or retraining).

Staff are encouraged to submit suggestions for improvement, either at meetings or directly to Marcus or Dana. All proposed changes are evaluated for feasibility, risk, and resource impact. Once implemented, effectiveness is evaluated after a predetermined period (at least quarterly), and further adjustments made as needed. Lessons learned are integrated into procedures, and staff are briefed on changes in team meetings. This approach ensures that improvements are neither one-time fixes nor isolated to individuals, but become embedded in Example LLC's operational system.